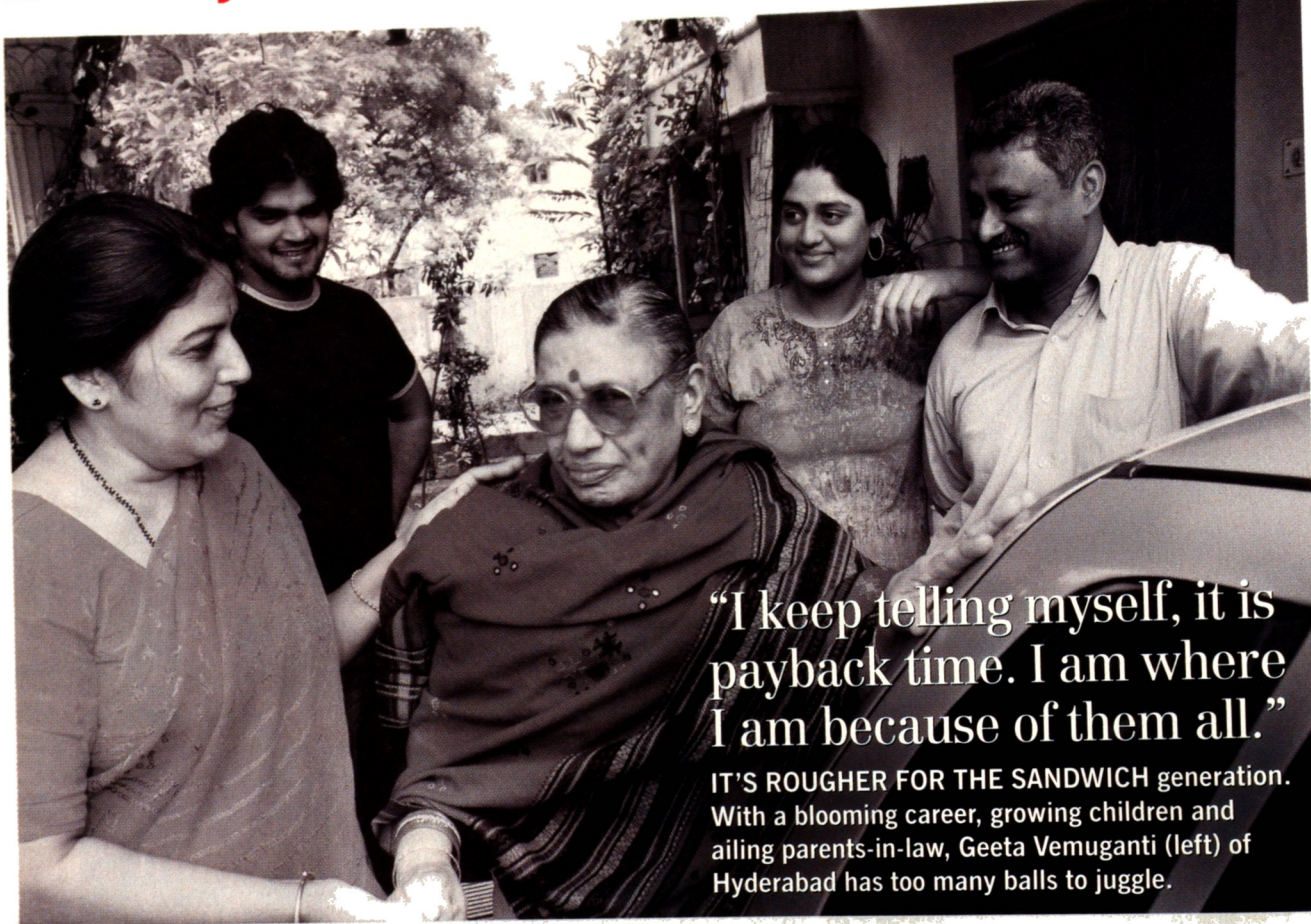




**"I keep telling myself, it is
payback time. I am where
I am because of them all."**

IT'S ROUGHER FOR THE SANDWICH generation. With a blooming career, growing children and ailing parents-in-law, Geeta Vemuganti (left) of Hyderabad has too many balls to juggle.

Old age BLUES



**What do the affluent lot
fear the most? Time—
loneliness, lack of work
and poor leisure hours.**



**Insufficient economic
resources and depend-
ence on children hurt
middle classes the most.**



**Lower classes fret about
poor health, disease,
lack of mobility and living
alone with disability.**



**Disrespect, neglect,
abuse and humiliation
make old age a 'disease',
feel all seniors.**

*Source: Elder Abuse In India, WHO Country
Report by HelpAge, 2002*

is on the rise," reports Satyajit Chakrabarty, who studied health-seeking behaviour of the elderly at the Achutha Menon Centre for Health Science Studies at Thiruvananthapuram. "But here most are economically dependent and the cost of treatment often proves to be a burden on the household." Only 30 per cent seniors seek treatment in India.

Health, as always, is linked to wealth. And the elderly are caught in an unfair financial squeeze: the high levels of economic dependence on others, especially for women. "Of the dependent elderly, support comes mostly from the children," points out Professor Indrani Gupta of Delhi University's Institute of Economic Growth. The National Sample Survey (NSS) data indicates that more than 70 per cent of the elderly are supported by their children. In a country where only 11 per cent of the population has any sort of guaranteed retirement income, the number of economically active elderly has gone up from 10 million in 1950 to 26 million in 2000. But the catch lies elsewhere.

"Economic dependency does not necessarily mean that the elderly owns no assets," adds Gupta. The NSS data shows, around 71 per cent of elderly men and 40 per cent of women own some financial assets. "Mere ownership, however, doesn't guarantee economic self-reliance," Gupta points out. The new reverse mortgage system, which will allow a senior citizen to mortgage property based on its valuation, may stand them in good stead in the future. For instance, if the assessed value of a flat—eligible for reverse mortgage—is Rs 8 lakh, it would yield approximately Rs 5,000 per month.

Two decades ago, caring for the elderly was hardly an issue. "Joint family was a good place to be very old and very young," says Professor N.K. Chadha of Delhi University, who specialises in gerontology. But in a globalised world, joint households are falling by the wayside. The great Indian family—large, noisy, with parents, children, uncles, aunts, cousins and grandparents, all living together under a single roof, squabbling but presenting a united